

PENCIL & PROMPT · COLORED PENCIL STUDY

Portrait Guide #015

Difficulty

Advanced

Est. time

8-12 hours

Subject

Alex Eala

Pencils

Prismacolor Premier

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• MATERIALS

*Prismacolor Premier pencils (list below)**Smooth-to-vellum paper with tooth**Kneaded eraser**Colourless blender or PC914 Cream for burnishing**Sharp pencil sharpener**Soft dry cloth (wax bloom)**Workable fixative (optional)*

PAPER — TOOTH IS THE BUDGET

Any smooth-to-vellum surface with tooth still in it. This portrait runs eight to ten layers in places, and the tooth is what holds them; on slick paper you run out of grip around layer four and nothing after that will sit down. Work light early so the tooth is still there when you need it.

PENCILS — EVERY NUMBER IS A ROLE, NOT A REQUIREMENT

The palette lists Prismacolor Premier because that is what was measured against the reference. Match the role — warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent — and a twelve-colour set will do the same job. Each step names the role alongside the number for exactly this reason.

BLENDER — BURNISH AT THE END, AND NEVER WITH SOLVENT

A colourless blender or a cream pencil, used only in the final pass. This guide builds value by dry layering; solvent dissolves the binder and flattens the tooth in one stroke, which removes every layer you still had left to spend. If the surface is not smooth enough, the answer is another light layer, never a wet one.

• COLOR PALETTE



Ginger Root

PC1084

Primary warm base skin tone; peachy-orange optical-mixing foundation matching measured #d2ba9f



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Warm transition tone for midface, cheeks, and unification passes



Sienna Brown

PC945

Warm shadow depth on cheekbones, sides of nose, form modeling



Light Umber

PC941

Warm mid-value shadow in eye sockets, under-chin, nasolabial fold



70% Warm Grey

PC1056

Mid-value neutral-warm form building, shadow edges, structural anchor (measured #715f5a)



90% Warm Grey

PC1058

Deep warm shadow grey for core shadows, never neutral; lip darkening (measured #594741)



Parma Violet

PC1008

Cool chromatic undertone glaze in shadow zones; eye socket depth; upper iris; the garment's violet reflected bounce



Greyed Lavender

PC1026

Subtle cool glaze for unifying shadow and reflected-light zones; gentle color shift



Blush Pink

PC928

Warm reflected light and glow in cheeks and shadow zones; subsurface scattering



Salmon Pink

PC1001

Warm optical-mixing layer; cheek and nose luminosity; lower iris; lip accent



90% Cool Grey

PC1067

Upper iris (shadowed half); soft lower lash line; cool background shadow



Indigo Blue

PC901

Deepest garment folds, upper lash line sharpness, eye pupil undertone, darkest hair zones



70% French Grey

PC1074

Neutral grey structural reference and value anchor (measured #807a70)



Black

PC935

Darkest pupil, upper lash line definition, near-black accents only. NEVER on the garment — black over violet kills it.



Goldenrod

PC1034

Warm cheek peak and nose-tip accent; reflected warm light; the lit top of the bun



Poppy Red

PC922

Saturated lip center intensity; warm mouth accent and life



Cream

PC914

Warm peak highlight glaze; burnishing base; final painted finish layer



White

PC938

Peak specular highlights (pupil catch light, forehead apex); reserved for brightest zones only



Dahlia Purple

PC1009

GARMENT BASE — the purple top; also a deep purple undertone in the hair underpainting



Black Raspberry

PC1095

Garment fold shadows; deep purple-red undertone in dark hair



Blue Slate

PC1024

Alternative upper lash line; cool accent



Powder Blue

PC1087

Upper sclera — the white of the eye is never white



Pale Sage

PC1089

Very soft lower lash line suggestion



Chocolate

PC1082

Hair mid-tone across the whole mass



Dark Brown

PC946

Hair shadow zones — underside of the bun, beside the face, at the nape



Bronze

PC1028

Warm hair mid-tone where light catches the top of the bun



Light Peach

PC927

Highest hair highlights on the bun's top surface and loose strands

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

What is the subject?

A young woman (estimated late teens to mid-20s) with dark hair worn UP IN A BUN and a few loosened strands falling onto the shoulders, warm medium-deep skin tone, and delicate, fine-featured facial structure. She wears a PURPLE top. She is gazing directly ahead with a calm, composed, and slightly contemplative expression. Her bearing is serene and luminous, suggesting youth, health, and emotional centeredness.

Material characteristics

Skin reads as translucent, smooth, and elastic with no visible texture, scarring, or aging markers — characteristic of youthful, well-hydrated skin. Hair is dense, dark (deep brown-black rather than pure black), with natural texture and subtle shine suggesting healthy hair. Because it is gathered into a bun it presents as TWO distinct masses — a wrapped, rounded coil carrying its own light and shadow, plus separate loose strands that fall onto the shoulders. Eyes are clear and bright with dark pupils and well-defined sclera, indicating alertness and youth. Overall skin has a subtle luminosity from subsurface light scattering, particularly visible at the nose tip, cheeks, and ears.

Geometric structure

Face is roughly oval to heart-shaped — wider at the forehead and cheekbones, narrowing toward a soft, gently rounded jawline that is not squared or heavily masculine. Jawline is delicate and integrated into the neck without a sharp angle. Cheekbones are moderately pronounced but not dramatic; they sit high on the face. Eyes are large relative to overall face width, set with a slight upward tilt toward the outer corners (doe-eye proportions characteristic of youth). Nose is fine, straight, with a soft bridge and delicate tip. Proportions are nearly symmetrical and harmonious, reading as balanced and aesthetically refined. Because the hair is worn up, the jaw, ears and full neck are exposed with nothing to hide behind — the neck is a load-bearing part of this drawing, not an afterthought.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Frontal, soft key light, suggesting diffused overcast daylight or gentle studio illumination from slightly above and centered. The light is not hard or directional (no pronounced side light or chiaroscuro modeling), but rather an enveloping, gentle illumination that wraps around the form. This soft frontal light allows the entire face to be visible and readable while still permitting subtle form modeling through value gradation rather than dramatic contrast.

MIDTONE

Lower cheeks, sides of the nose, the broad central planes of the face, lower forehead, upper neck, values that carry the portrait's primary color temperature.

Edge quality notes

Edges throughout are predominantly soft and diffused, reflecting both the roundness of the facial form and the softness of the key light. The terminator (the boundary between lit and shadow zones) on the cheekbones and jaw is gradual, not crisp, occurring over roughly 1–2 inches of face width. The single exception is the upper lash line (the edge of the upper eyelid as it occludes light), which reads as the sharpest, darkest, most defined edge in the entire portrait — this edge hierarchy serves as the focal-point anchor. All other edges (lower lash line, jawline, hair-to-face, face-to-neck, neck-to-garment, hair-to-background) are progressively softer and more diffused, creating a hierarchy that directs attention upward to the eyes.

COLOR ANALYSIS

Overall temperature

Warm overall — the dominant skin temperature is neutral-warm peachy-tan, never cool or ashy. Even shadow zones carry warm undertones (warm greys, warm browns, warm ochres) rather than sliding toward blue or cool grey. However, the reference contains measured cool undertones (the PURPLE garment; cool violets in shadow mixing, PC1008 Parma Violet) that play a supporting optical-mixing role, not as the dominant temperature. The portrait reads as a warm-lit subject with cool accents, not as a cool-lit subject.

Light zone tendency

Lit planes shift toward warm yellow-peach and cream, intensifying and enriching the warm base skin tone. The brightest zones (nose tip, forehead apex, cheekbone peaks) read as warm peachy-cream, never as cool highlights or cool reflections. Even where light strikes the skin most directly, warmth dominates.

Shadow zone tendency

Shadow zones (eye sockets, nasolabial folds, under-chin, beneath lower lip) shift toward warm-neutral brown and warm grey, with a subtle cool undertone glaze (Parma Violet or Greyed Lavender) applied thinly as an optical-mixing layer to keep them luminous and prevent them from reading as dead, ashy, or plastic. The underlying tone remains WARM and MID-VALUE; the cool glaze is a thin, translucent veil over this warm base, not a primary color. This is critical: shadows must stay warm and mid-value in soft frontal light, never become heavy, dark, cool, or ashy.

Special color areas

Cheeks: the peak of each cheekbone reads as the warmest and most saturated zone (shifting toward warm rose and salmon); lips: the upper lip reads as darker and cooler (warm grey or muted brown-red), while the lower lip reads as lighter and more saturated (warm pink-red with a tiny Poppy Red accent at the center); eyes: pupils are very dark (near-black with warm brown undertones to prevent them from reading as holes), the upper iris reflects cool violet from the purple garment; nose: tip reads warmest and lightest due to subsurface scattering; hair: dark brown-black with warm ochre undertones on the lit top of the bun, and subtle cool violet reflections from the garment where the loose strands fall near it.

Saturation distribution

Saturation is moderate overall — the face is neither vivid/neon nor desaturated/grey, but rather reads as naturally saturated. Cheeks and lips carry the highest saturation (warm rose, salmon, Poppy Red accents), making them secondary focal points after the eyes. Eyes carry high saturation (dark saturated pupils, warm or cool iris undertones). Hair is desaturated overall (deep, muted brown-black, never bright or vivid). Garment is a moderately DESATURATED purple — keep it muted, because violet sits closer to the reds in skin than a blue-grey would and a vivid garment pulls attention off the face. Background/neutral zones are desaturated (grey, cream). This saturation hierarchy supports the attention-direction strategy: high saturation at eyes and mouth (focal points), decreasing saturation toward the periphery.

01 Light Value Structure Map (Monochrome Foundation)

Entire face, ears, and upper neck from chin to garment edge

Layered strokes

Light to Medium pressure

Light circular strokes of PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) over the entire face at low pressure, covering every visible skin zone uniformly. On a second pass, use PC1058 (90% Warm Grey) to deepen only the recessed and shadowed zones (eye sockets, nasolabial fold, underside of chin, beneath lower lip). Keep the second pass light-to-medium pressure; the shadows should be mid-value, not heavy. Preserve paper tooth by working light and letting multiple passes build value rather than pressing hard in one or two passes. Establish the full value range — from the brightest lit plane (forehead apex, nose tip, cheekbone peaks) to the deepest local shadow (eye sockets, under-chin) — without introducing color yet. This monochrome pass trains your eye to read the actual three-dimensional light geometry independent of hue, preventing later color layers from confusing form. Use light-to-medium pressure and circular strokes; apply PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) lightly across the entire face, then on a second pass deepen only the shadow zones (eye sockets, nasolabial fold, under-chin) with PC1058 (90% Warm Grey) at slightly higher pressure. Keep all values mid-range; do NOT block in heavy darks yet — paper tooth is precious. The reason: colored pencil is a layering medium, and layering requires a solid value scaffold first. Without this structure, color alone will confuse the three-dimensional form and create a flat, painted appearance rather than a luminous, sculptural portrait. This pass is your foundation; rush it and every later layer will fight uphill.

COLORS

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC1058 90% Warm Grey

Many artists invert this strategy — they block in a dark overall value and then layer light pencils on top, which crushes paper tooth early and limits later layers. Instead, think of this pass as placing value anchors: 'Here is my lightest zone (forehead), here is my darkest zone (eye socket), and here is my midtone (cheek).' These anchors become the reference grid for all color layers to come. If you nail the value structure, the colors layer almost effortlessly.

02 Cool Undertone Glaze in Shadow Zones (Chromatic Shadow Foundation)

Eye sockets, nasolabial fold, underside of chin, zone beneath the lower lip, sides of neck

Layered strokes

Light pressure

Very light circular strokes of PC1008 (Parma Violet) into the deepest shadow pockets (eye sockets, the shadowed side of the nasolabial fold). Use PC1026 (Greyed Lavender) as a softer, gentler variant in secondary shadow zones (cheek shadow near the jaw, underside of chin, neck shadow). Pressure must be light so the warm base remains dominant; the cool is a veil, not a replacement. Shadow zones in skin are inherently cool due to reflected environment light (sky, garment), so introduce a thin chromatic glaze of Parma Violet or Greyed Lavender into recessed and shadow areas to prevent them from reading as dead neutral grey. Use very light pressure and circular strokes so the layer is translucent; the warm value layer below must show through, creating an optical mix that reads alive and luminous rather than plastic or ashy. The reason: skin scatters light. Where light recedes (shadow), reflected cool light from the environment bounces up into the shadow zone. By layering cool over warm, you simulate this optical reality — the eye fuses cool glaze + warm base into a single luminous shadow, which is what real skin does. A shadow rendered in neutral grey alone, or in heavy cool without a warm base, reads as bruising, damage, or lifelessness.

COLORS



PC1008 Parma
Violet



PC1026 Greyed
Lavender

The failure mode is applying cool shadow with heavy pressure, which flattens the cool over the warm, creating mud and losing the optical mixing effect. Light pressure preserves the layering and allows the eye to fuse the two colors. Think 'transparency,' not 'coverage.' If the shadow reads muddy or plastic after this step, the pressure was too heavy — ease back, lighten it, and re-layer at lower pressure.

03 Warm Base Skin Tone Layer (Unified Foundation for Optical Mixing)

Entire face, ears, and visible neck down to garment edge

Layered strokes

Light to Medium pressure

Light to medium pressure, circular strokes, full-face coverage. Work in systematic zones (forehead, left cheek, right cheek, nose area, mouth area, chin, ears, visible neck) to ensure even application without pressing harder in any one zone. The goal is unification, not modeling — do not attempt to create value variation (darks and lights) in this pass. Simply lay down the warm hue uniformly. This step is the slowest and most deliberate; take your time to achieve even coverage that will serve as the visual 'voice' for the entire portrait. Build a unified, warm peachy-orange base across the entire skin area at light-to-medium pressure. This layer is the backbone of optical mixing — all subsequent layers (shadows, cheek warmth, highlights) sit on top of this base and mix with it optically, creating luminosity and depth rather than a stack of flat colors. Use Ginger Root (PC1084, the measured #d2ba9f peachy-orange) as the primary layer, applying it evenly and uniformly across the whole face so that every single millimeter of skin has the same warm foundation before any local deepening or lightening. The reason: skin IS warm, and building from a warm base prevents cool shadows or pale highlights from sliding into grey, ashy, or plastic-looking. Even where you will later glaze cool shadow undertones or cream highlights, this warm layer anchors everything as flesh tone rather than as an abstract color sketch.

COLORS

● PC1084 Ginger
Root

This is where many portraitists fail — they jump directly to local color (dark cheek shadow, light forehead, light nose) in one pass, creating a patchwork of separate zones that never unifies. By laying one warm tone across the entire face first at a consistent light-to-medium pressure, you establish a unified visual foundation. Every color layer that follows harmonizes with this base. The unification step at the end will be far easier because the foundation is already unified. Resist the urge to model; just layer the base.

04 Midtone Form Building (Sienna and Warm Grey for Structure)

Cheekbone transition zones, sides of nose, lower forehead, jaw edge, ear, neck sides

Directional strokes

Light to Medium pressure

Light-to-medium pressure, using PC945 (Sienna Brown) in the cheekbone transition zone and beside the sides of the nose where the nose plane turns. Use PC1080 (Beige Sienna) in the lower cheek and jaw transition area to bridge the lit and shadow zones smoothly. Apply directional strokes that echo the contour of the face (curved strokes that follow the rounded plane). Do not fill densely; aim for translucency so the warm base shows through and mixes optically. Deepen the midtones and introduce form using Sienna Brown and Warm Grey to model the rounded structure of the face. Apply these at light-to-medium pressure in the zones where the face turns away from the light — the sides of the nose, the transition from cheekbone peak to cheek, the sides of the lower face near the jaw, and the ear. This step creates dimension by shifting value without yet creating hard shadows. The reason: in soft frontal light, form does NOT emerge from dramatic core shadows or hard edges, but rather from a careful value gradient — a transition zone. By placing warm midtones now (not heavy darks), you preserve the luminous quality of soft light while still reading volume and three-dimensionality. Form emerges through subtle value steps, not through dark hollows.

COLORS

● PC945 Sienna
Brown

● PC1080 Beige
Sienna

When light is soft and frontal, the temptation is to keep the face flat and evenly lit — resist this. Even soft light has form; it emerges through subtle value steps and temperature shifts, not through hard edges or dark hollows. The key is knowing when to stop: if your midtones read as dark blobs or dramatic shadows, you have pressed too hard or placed value too dark. Keep every midtone warmer and lighter than your instinct suggests. If you doubt yourself, erase with a kneaded eraser and re-layer lighter.

05 Shadow Depth and Edge Placement (Warm Shadows for Form Turn)

Eye sockets, nasolabial fold, under-nose zone, beneath lower lip, underside of chin self-shadow

Directional strokes

Medium pressure

Medium pressure, using PC941 (Light Umber) for eye socket shadows and subtle fold shadows. Use PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) to build the self-shadow under the chin and on the sides of the neck. Employ soft circular strokes in socket areas and directional strokes following the line of the nasolabial fold or jaw edge. Do NOT build this shadow in one heavy pass — layer it across 2-3 light passes instead, allowing optical mixing and preventing over-darkening. Place the core shadows that define facial structure — the recess of the eye socket, the subtle fold beside the mouth, the soft self-shadow under the chin where the face turns into the neck. These shadows are the DARKEST local darks in the face (apart from pupils and hair shadow), but because this reference has soft frontal light, they remain MID-VALUE and WARM, never heavy or cool-dark. Use Light Umber and Warm Grey at medium pressure, building from the warm base already in place. The reason: core shadows must be warm and mid-value to read as 'form-turning-away-from-light' rather than as damage, bruising, or blemish. A cool, dark shadow in soft frontal light reads as a hole or defect; a warm, mid-value shadow reads as the natural structure of the head and neck.

COLORS

● PC941 Light
Umber

● PC1056 70% Warm
Grey

The most common error in soft-light portraiture is over-darkening shadows out of fear that the face will read flat. But the reference itself is not dark — the eye sockets are MID- VALUE, not dramatic hollows. Match the reference's actual contrast, not the contrast you think a face 'should' have. Compare your shadow value to the measured reference by placing a grey swatch nearby. If your shadows are darker, erase some with a kneaded eraser and re-layer more lightly. Trust the reference.

06 Eye Rendering — Pupil, Iris, and Upper Lid Shadow

Both eyes; pupils, iris, upper lid shadow, and iris-sclera boundary

Layered strokes

Medium to Heavy (pupil), Medium (iris radial strokes), Light (shadow glaze) pressure

Start with PC935 (Black) at medium-heavy pressure for the pupil, placed at 12 o'clock within the iris circle (not centered) to suggest a catch light above. Layer PC901 (Indigo Blue) as a subtle undertone under black if the pupil reads too flat. Use PC1067 (90% Cool Grey) and PC1001 (Salmon Pink) in radial strokes (radiating outward from the pupil) to build iris form: warmer/salmon on the lower iris, cooler/grey on the upper iris. Glaze PC1008 (Parma Violet) over the upper iris and upper lid shadow — the upper iris takes a violet reflection from the purple garment, so it leans violet rather than plain grey. Work with a sharp pencil point for precision; pressure varies from heavy (pupil) to medium (iris radial strokes) to light (shadow glaze). The eyes are the focal point and demand precision. Begin with the darkest element — the pupil — placing it with a sharp pencil at medium-heavy pressure to establish depth and anchor the direct gaze. Layer the iris around the pupil using radial strokes (from pupil outward) with multiple hues: warm brown or ochre on the lower iris (lit), cool violet-grey on the upper iris (shadowed, reflecting the purple garment), warm ring at the iris edge. Finally, glaze the upper lid's cast shadow (the shadow the upper eyelid casts onto the sclera below) with cool shadow tone. The reason: the eye is a sphere in a socket. The pupil must read as darkest to establish depth. The iris must show form through radial layering (not a flat filled circle). The upper lid shadow anchors the eye to its socket, preventing it from floating on the surface.

COLORS

● PC935
Black

● PC901 Indigo
Blue

● PC1067 90% Cool
Grey

● PC1001 Salmon
Pink

● PC1008 Parma
Violet

The most common error is rendering the iris as a flat colored circle — this reads as a painted-on shape, not as a three-dimensional eye. Real iris form: the top reads slightly darker and cooler (shadowed by the brow and lid), the bottom reads slightly lighter and warmer (lit from below by reflected light). Build this form by varying hue and pressure. The pupil itself should never be pure black if the overall light is warm; a touch of dark brown or dark blue under the black keeps it from looking like a hole in the head.

07 Eye Rendering — Sclera, Catch Light, and Upper Lash Line (Focal Point)

Both eyes; sclera (whites), catch light (highlight), upper lash line, lower lash line

Layered strokes

Light (sclera and catch light area), Heavy (upper lash line), Light (lower lash line) pressure

Build the sclera with very light PC1087 (Powder Blue) on the upper portion and very light PC914 (Cream) on the lower portion using light pressure and circular strokes. Leave a tiny white-paper highlight at 12 o'clock in the pupil; you will reinforce it in the final burnish if needed. Draw the upper lash line with PC901 (Indigo Blue) or PC1024 (Blue Slate) using a sharp pencil point and HEAVY pressure — this is the hardest, crispest line in the entire portrait and sets the focus hierarchy. Draw the lower lash line with PC1067 (90% Cool Grey) or even PC1089 (Pale Sage) at very light pressure so it reads as soft suggestion, not definition. The sclera (white of the eye) is never pure white — it reads as light blue-grey or cream, slightly warmer on the lower half (lit surface) and slightly cooler on the upper half (shadowed). Reserve pure white ONLY for the single specular highlight (catch light), positioned at 12 o'clock in the pupil. The upper lash line is the SHARPEST, DARKEST EDGE in the entire portrait — this is your focal-point anchor and must be rendered crisply and darkly. The lower lash line, by contrast, stays soft, diffuse, and subtle. The reason: the eye has volume and translucency. The sclera scatters light and is never stark white. The upper lid occludes light, reads dark, and is sharp (hard edge). The lower lid is exposed and soft. The hard upper lash line is what locks viewer focus and prevents the eye from reading as flat or lifeless.

COLORS

PC1087 Powder
Blue

PC914
Cream

PC938
White

PC901 Indigo
Blue

PC1024 Blue
Slate

PC1067 90% Cool
Grey

PC1089 Pale
Sage

The upper lash line is not a perfect, uniform line — study the reference closely: where is it heaviest (usually at the inner corner and center)? Where does it thin or break (usually outer corner)? Where does it feather or have gaps? Render these subtleties; a perfect heavy line reads as false and robotic. And remember the hierarchy: this hard dark line belongs ONLY at the upper lid. By keeping the lower lash line soft and the outer eye edge diffuse, you direct all attention to the sharpest, darkest point — the focal anchor.

08 Skin Unification Pass (Light Peachy-Warm Glaze)

Entire face, ears, and visible neck

Layered strokes

Light pressure

Very light circular strokes of PC1084 (Ginger Root) over the entire face in a systematic pass, followed by a second pass of PC1080 (Beige Sienna) in the same manner. Keep pressure minimal — you are TINTING, not re-coloring. Work methodically across forehead, left cheek, right cheek, nose, lips, chin, ears, and down the visible neck. This pass should take only 2–3 minutes; speed is fine as long as pressure stays light. Before moving to local color accents (cheeks, lips, nose warmth), unify the face under a transparent overall glaze of warm peachy tone at very light pressure. This pass smooths transitions between zones, harmonizes color discrepancies, and prevents the face from reading as separate patches of color. Use Ginger Root or Beige Sienna at very light pressure in circular strokes across every zone — this is NOT a heavy re-layer, just a unifying wash. The reason: at this stage, the face likely shows value transitions, multiple hues, and modeling, which is correct progress, but the zones may appear slightly disjointed or blocky. A light overall glaze ties them into a single, cohesive, luminous surface — which is what real skin does under light. It sits as one material, not as separate zones.

COLORS



PC1084 Ginger
Root



PC1080 Beige
Sienna

This unification pass is often skipped because artists want to move to local color 'right away.' But it is NOT optional — it is the difference between a portrait that reads as a cohesive painted work and one that reads as an assembled collage of zones. The pass takes minimal time but pays enormous dividends in visual coherence and professional finish. Never skip it.

09 Cheek and Nose Warmth Accent (Subsurface Scattering Glow)

Cheekbone peaks (both sides), nose tip, bridge of nose, ear lobes

Layered strokes

Medium pressure

Use PC928 (Blush Pink) at light-medium pressure in the center of each cheekbone zone (not extending far down the jaw). Layer PC1001 (Salmon Pink) over the nose tip and bridge in small circular strokes at medium pressure. Add PC1034 (Goldenrod) as a tiny accent at the apex of each cheekbone (the highest point where light hits hardest) at medium pressure. Keep these warm zones diffused and feathered outward with soft edges; use circular strokes that blend gradually into the surrounding tone, not hard boundaries. Cheeks and the nose tip are zones of subsurface scattering — light penetrates thin skin, bounces within tissue, and exits as warm red-pink and orange luminosity. These zones must read warmer and more saturated than the surrounding face to signal health and vitality. Layer Blush Pink, Salmon Pink, and Goldenrod into the cheekbone peaks and nose tip at medium pressure in focused strokes. The reason: this is the 'life' and 'glow' of the portrait — without cheek and nose warmth, the face reads ashen and lifeless. Because this reference has soft frontal light, these warm accents are modest and diffused, not sharp — but they must still read as intentional warmth, not just a lighter shade of the base tone.

COLORS



PC928 Blush
Pink



PC1001 Salmon
Pink



PC1034
Goldenrod

The failure mode is the 'clown blush' — two round patches of color stuck on the face. This happens when you place warmth too far forward on the cheek or apply it too brightly and with hard edges. Keep the warm zone small (roughly fingertip-sized) and positioned at the actual cheekbone peak (find it by sucking in the cheeks and locating the bone ridge at its highest point). The warmth sits at the intersection of the lit plane and the turning plane, where subsurface scattering is strongest. Feather the edges so it integrates into the face.

10 Lip Rendering (Upper Shadow, Lower Glow, and Saturation)

Both lips; upper lip, lower lip, lip line, lip corners

Layered strokes

Medium (upper lip), Medium-Light (lower lip), Medium (Poppy Red accent) pressure

Apply PC1058 (90% Warm Grey) or a mix of PC941 (Light Umber) layered under PC1001 (Salmon Pink) to the upper lip at medium pressure, creating a subtle shadow that suggests the upper lip's form-turning-away. Layer PC928 (Blush Pink) and PC1001 (Salmon Pink) to the lower lip at light-medium pressure. Add a tiny accent of PC922 (Poppy Red) to the lower lip center (roughly where the lower lip curves highest) at medium pressure in a short horizontal stroke. Soften the lip line by blending with a colorless blender or a very light pass of PC1084 (Ginger Root) so the mouth integrates into the face rather than appearing as a painted-on shape. Lips anchor expression and humanize the portrait. The upper lip reads darker and cooler (shadowed by its own thickness and the nose shadow above it); the lower lip reads lighter and warmer (the light-catching curved surface). NEVER render the mouth with a hard outline — instead, integrate the lip line softly into the surrounding face using subtle value and color shifts. Use warm grey or muted brown-red on the upper lip at medium pressure; shift to warm pink-red on the lower lip at medium-light pressure. Reserve the most saturated tone (Poppy Red) for a tiny accent on the lower lip center. The reason: the mouth is not a separate feature but an integral part of facial form and expression. The value difference between upper and lower lip reads the volume and curvature; the color difference (cool-dark upper, warm-saturated lower) reads the direction of light.

COLORS

● PC1058 90% Warm Grey

● PC928 Blush Pink

● PC1001 Salmon Pink

● PC922 Poppy Red

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC1084 Ginger Root

The temptation is to make the lip line very clear and dark — resist this. In soft-light portraiture, the lip line should be nearly invisible, suggested only by value shift. Think of the mouth as a crease, not a line, and render it through value and color change, not line work. The Poppy Red accent should be subtle — barely visible unless studied closely — suggesting a warm highlight on the lower lip's curve, not a strong saturated band.

11 Hair Underpainting (Dark Warm Browns and Deep Purples)

TWO masses: the gathered bun, and the loosened strands falling onto the shoulders

Directional strokes

Low to Medium pressure

The hair is worn UP IN A BUN with loosened strands on the shoulders, so it is two masses drawn two different ways. On the BUN use curved strokes following the wrap of the coil — around the form, not down it — changing direction wherever a section visibly turns. On the LOOSE STRANDS use long strokes running down and slightly outward, in separate groups with gaps between them. Use PC945 (Sienna Brown) at low-medium pressure for both. Layer PC1095 (Black Raspberry) or PC1009 (Dahlia Purple) in a second pass to add purple undertones and deepen select shadow areas (zones between hair clumps, where hair overlaps neck or background). Place PC901 (Indigo Blue) in the deepest shadow zones. Place the DARKEST value of the whole hair mass in the crevice where the bun meets the head, and in the shadow the bun casts onto the crown — that single dark is what makes the bun sit on the head instead of hovering above it. Keep pressure low and maintain each mass's stroke direction consistently — do not cross-hatch or work in random directions; the stroke direction is part of the illusion. Hair is rendered from dark to light — begin by establishing the darkest values and overall mass structure before adding mid-tones and highlights. Start with an underpainting using dark warm brown and deep purple at low-to-medium pressure following each mass's own direction: curved around the coil on the bun, full-length and downward on the loose strands. The bun is a wrapped, rounded form and carries its own light and shadow like any rounded object — drawn with downward strokes it flattens into a patch stuck to the head. This underpainting establishes form, shadows between hair clumps, and the illusion of density. The reason: 'black' hair is never pure black; it is built from warm browns, deep purples, and cool dark blues layered and optically mixed. By starting with warm and cool undertones rather than pure black, the hair reads as real texture, not as a flat dark shape. Directional strokes reinforce the illusion of structure and flow.

COLORS



PC945 Sienna
Brown



PC1095 Black
Raspberry



PC901 Indigo
Blue



PC1009 Dahlia
Purple

The most common failure in dark hair is rendering it as a flat, featureless mass — either solid black or an even dark brown with no dimension. The key is to preserve and exaggerate the light pattern already visible in the reference: where does light hit the hair mass? That zone remains lighter through all passes. Where does hair sink into shadow? That zone reads darker. Even now in the underpainting, exaggerate this light pattern: layer lighter (browns) where light catches, darker (purples, blues) where light recedes. This pattern will guide later layers and prevent the hair from becoming a uniform blob.

12 Hair Mid-Tones and Structure Refinement (Building Density and Form)

Entire hair mass; shadow zones between clumps, around the face periphery, at the nape

Directional strokes

Medium (shadows), Light to Medium (mid-tones) pressure

Layer PC1082 (Chocolate) in full-length strokes over existing brown undertones at medium pressure. Add PC946 (Dark Brown) in the shadow zones at medium pressure — on the BUN, the underside of the coil and wherever sections overlap one another (that overlap shadow is what reads as 'wrapped'); on the LOOSE STRANDS, beside the face and at the nape. Use PC1028 (Bronze) as a warmer mid-tone where light catches — on the bun this is the top of the coil, where the light actually lands, at light-to-medium pressure. Vary pressure — medium in shadows, light in mid-tones — so values build gradually rather than jumping from light underpainting to heavy dark in one step. Maintain directional strokes throughout. Deepen hair values using dark browns and near-blacks at medium pressure, building density and structure while maintaining directional stroke pattern (following actual hair growth). Layer new hues and values in thin, multiple passes rather than one heavy layer — each pass adds visual complexity and depth without making hair look waxy or overworked. Continue full-length directional strokes; avoid circular or random strokes that muddy the directional illusion. The reason: hair has a grain; light and shadow follow that grain. By maintaining directional strokes across multiple passes, you reinforce the illusion of hair as a material with structure and flow. Hair rendered with non-directional scribbles reads as abstract texture, not as actual hair.

COLORS



PC1082
Chocolate



PC946 Dark
Brown



PC1028
Bronze

If your hair at this stage looks muddy or flat, the cause is usually non-directional strokes or excessive pressure in early layers. Erase gently with a kneaded eraser to lift some value back to a mid-tone, then re-layer with directional strokes at lighter pressure. The remedy is always to work lighter and more selectively, never to press harder. Pressure control is everything in dark hair.

13 Hair Highlights and Light Layering (Catching the Light Pattern)

Bun: a broad band across the top surface. Loose strands: narrow separate catch-lights on individual groups.

Directional strokes

Light to Medium pressure

Use PC1080 (Beige Sienna) in light strokes (medium pressure, shorter length) in the most-lit zones. The BUN is a rounded form, so light lands on it as a broad soft BAND across its top surface, not as individual strands; the LOOSE STRANDS take narrow separate catch-lights along individual groups. Do not give them the same treatment — that difference is the whole reason the bun reads as a bun. Layer PC927 (Light Peach) in even lighter strokes in the very highest-lit zones. Add tiny accents of PC1034 (Goldenrod) where warm light reflects (especially near the face, where warm skin light bounces into adjacent hair). Keep all strokes directional and preserve paper white. This is a selective, restrained pass, not a heavy layer. In the final hair pass before detail work, introduce the light pattern by layering light-to-medium browns and warm tones in zones where light catches the hair surface. Use lighter pressure and shorter strokes (often the tips or outer edges of the hair mass) to suggest individual shine and texture. Do NOT layer white or very light cream here — preserve paper white for the final burnishing pass. Instead, use light browns and warm mid-tones that read light through CONTRAST with the surrounding darks. The reason: highlights in dark hair read not through absolute lightness but through relative value contrast. By placing light tones against dark tones in the final passes, you create visual sparkle and the illusion of shiny, healthy hair without depleting paper tooth or creating artificial-looking white streaks.

COLORS

PC1080 Beige
Sienna

PC927 Light
Peach

PC1034
Goldenrod

This is where patience pays off — the highlight layer is what separates luminous, living hair from a dead dark mass. But it is also where artists over-lighten or over-apply. Study the reference: where are the lightest hairs? Usually only the topmost layer or a few strands along the periphery. A few well-placed light strokes read as 'light catching the surface'; many strokes read as 'the hair is actually light-colored.' Restrain yourself and keep light layers selective.

14 Neck Rendering and Skin-to-Garment Transition (Form and Integration)

Visible neck from chin to garment edge; underside of chin, front and sides of neck, neck-to-shoulder junction

Directional strokes

Light to Medium pressure

Continue the warm base tone (PC1084, PC1080) down the front of the neck at light pressure, maintaining the same unification strategy as the face. Apply PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) and PC941 (Light Umber) to the underside of the chin and the sides of the neck (where neck turns into shadow or garment) at medium pressure. Use soft circular strokes in shadow zones and directional downward strokes on the lit front. Soften all neck-to-shoulder and neck-to-garment edges with very light pressure or a colorless blender until they integrate smoothly. Because the hair is worn up, the neck is fully exposed with nothing over it — this is a load-bearing part of the drawing, not an afterthought. The neck is a critical transition — it carries skin tone from the face but shifts subtly in value and temperature as it descends and into shadow. The underside of the chin (where jaw meets neck) reads as a soft self-shadow; the front of the neck in light reads lighter than the face; the sides may take reflected violet from the purple garment. Render this zone with careful attention to soft shadow edges and subtle color shifts. Apply warm base tones (Ginger Root, Beige Sienna) from face down through neck at light-to-medium pressure; deepen with Warm Grey and Light Umber in shadow zones. The reason: the neck is often overlooked, but it is the mechanical link between head and body. A well-rendered neck reads professional and integrated; a neglected or too-dark neck breaks the portrait's continuity and makes the head appear to float.

COLORS

● PC1084 Ginger Root

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC941 Light Umber

The underside-of-chin shadow is a common fail point — artists either leave it too light (the neck reads detached from the head) or render it too dark (it reads as bruising or injury). The correct value reads as a mid-value warm shadow, slightly deeper than the surrounding neck but NOT as dark as core face shadows. Study the reference: the underside of the chin is a gentle darkening, not a hard edge or dramatic hollow. Render this as a soft value shift, not as a line or a blob.

15 Garment Rendering — Base and Shadow Form (Purple Layering)

Visible garment; neckline, shoulders, any folds or shadow regions in the fabric

Directional strokes

Light to Medium (base), Medium (shadows), Light (edges) pressure

Layer PC1009 (Dahlia Purple) over the garment area at light-to-medium pressure in circular or loose directional strokes (no particular direction required here; focus on even coverage). Layer PC1095 (Black Raspberry) in fold shadows and where fabric darkens; use PC901 (Indigo Blue) sparingly in the deepest folds — it cools the violet without killing it, and PC1008 (Parma Violet) lightly on the lit face of any fold. Do NOT use PC935 (Black) here: black over violet turns it grey-brown and dead, and it cannot be recovered. Keep the garment's edges soft where it meets the face or neck (use light pressure or a colorless blender to blend); keep any outer edges softer still. Do not render fine fabric texture or weave — the garment should read as a simple shape that frames and supports the face. The garment is PURPLE — a mid-value, desaturated violet. It does not dominate the portrait — the face is focal — so render it more simply and with softer edges than the face. Apply the base purple at light-to-medium pressure over the garment area; then deepen with deep purple-red and indigo in shadow zones (folds, where fabric turns into shadow, where it meets the neck). The reason: the garment provides a cool color anchor that sets off the warm face. But note that violet is a much closer neighbour to skin on the colour wheel than a blue-grey would be — violet sits beside the red in flesh tone, so a saturated purple will fight the face instead of receding behind it. Keep it desaturated and keep it darker than the face, and it will push the warm face forward and direct all visual attention upward. Additionally, any reflected light from the garment onto the lower jaw or neck reads as a subtle violet bounce, which is optically correct and adds sophistication.

COLORS



PC1009 Dahlia
Purple



PC1095 Black
Raspberry



PC901 Indigo
Blue



PC1008 Parma
Violet

A common error is rendering the garment with the same level of detail and sharpness as the face — this splits attention. By keeping the garment simple, soft-edged, and slightly less contrasted than the face, you ensure that the viewer's eye is drawn upward to the face, especially the eyes. The garment should feel like negative space — important for composition and color balance, but not demanding attention.

16 Reflected Color and Garment-to-Skin Integration (Violet Bounce and Unity)

Lower jaw, underside of chin, sides of neck immediately above the garment neckline

Layered strokes

Light pressure

Use PC1008 (Parma Violet) in very light strokes along the upper edge of the garment, feathering upward onto the lower jaw and neck by one-quarter to one-half inch. Follow with PC1026 (Greyed Lavender) in even lighter strokes in the same zones to soften and desaturate the bounce. Keep pressure minimal — these are glazes, not heavy layers, and violet on warm skin goes to mud faster than a grey would, so too much hand here turns a subtle bounce into a bruise on the jaw. Blend the edges of these cool zones into the warm skin using a colorless blender or very light circular strokes so the transition reads gradual, not patchy. The purple garment casts a cool VIOLET reflected-light bounce upward onto the lower face and neck. This reflected color is subtle but critical for optical realism — without it, the neck appears to float on top of the garment rather than sit as part of a unified figure. Introduce a thin, cool glaze (Parma Violet, softened with Greyed Lavender) in areas immediately above the garment neckline, allowing the cool to mix optically with the warm skin tones below. The reason: light does not stop at a single surface; it bounces. The garment's violet sends cool light upward, mixing with warm skin to create a luminous, unified interface. Parma Violet is also the pencil used for the shadow undertone glaze back in Step 2, so the bounce and the shadows now belong to one cool family rather than two competing ones. This is color physics, not decoration — ignoring it reads as separate zones rather than as a convincing three-dimensional figure.

COLORS



PC1008 Parma
Violet



PC1026 Greyed
Lavender

This step is where many tutorials fall short because they do not address the physics of reflected light — but it is the difference between a portrait that looks assembled (separate face, neck, garment) and one that looks unified (a continuous figure with light bouncing between surfaces). Spend time on this step even though it seems small; it elevates the entire work to a professional level.

17 Detail Refinement and Edge Hierarchy (Sharpening the Focal Point)

Eyes, lash lines, facial features; hair texture and edge separation; jawline and cheek edges

Layered strokes

Heavy (upper lash line), Light (individual lashes and softening edges) pressure

Sharpen PC901 (Indigo Blue) or PC935 (Black) at the upper lash line in fine lines at sharp pencil point and HEAVY pressure. Add individual lashes at the outer corner with PC935 (Black) at very light pressure — 2-3 lashes suggesting mass, not rendering every lash. Soften the lower lash line with very light PC1026 (Greyed Lavender) or by blending with a colorless blender. Feather the jawline and cheek-to-neck edge using light circular strokes with surrounding colors (Warm Grey, Ginger Root) at very light pressure. Reduce contrast and soften the outer hair outline by lightening it with PC914 (Cream) or blending into the background. With major forms complete, refine details and sharpen the focal point (the eyes and upper lash line) while simultaneously softening edges elsewhere (cheeks, jaw, hair outline) to direct attention. Reinforce the upper lash line with a sharp dark pencil at heavy pressure to ensure it reads as the darkest, crispest edge in the entire portrait. Add individual lash strokes at the outer eye corners with very light pressure. Soften the jawline, cheek-to-neck edge, and hair-to-background edge by feathering them with light pressure or a colorless blender so they become softer and diffuse. The reason: edge hierarchy is the PRIMARY tool for directing attention. Hard edges advance and demand focus; soft and lost edges recede and allow the eye to move past. By making the eyes the hardest and most detailed zone and progressively softening everything else, you create visual hierarchy that reads as intentional and finished.

COLORS

● PC901 Indigo
Blue

● PC935
Black

● PC914
Cream

● PC1026 Greyed
Lavender

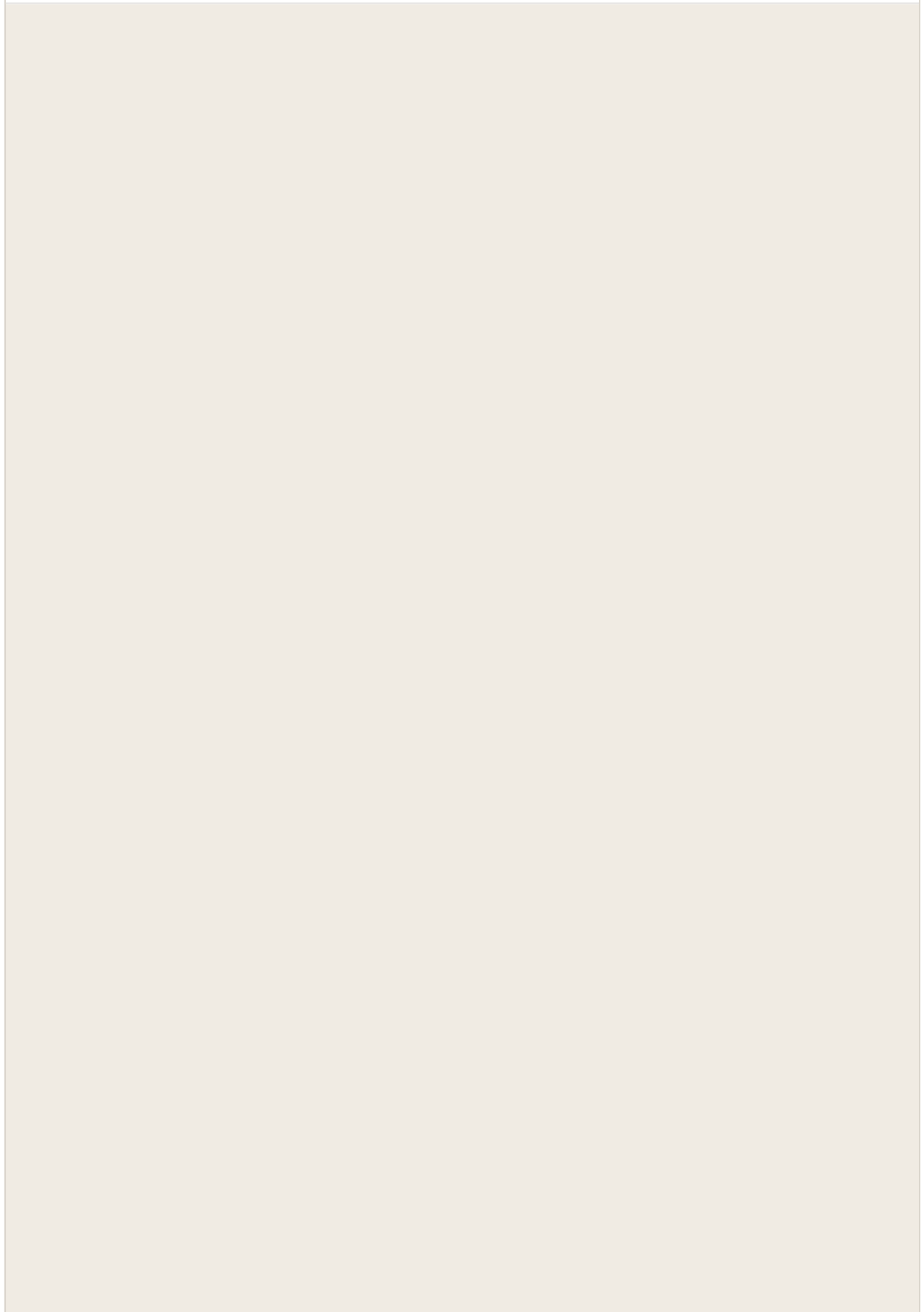
The hardest habit to break is uniform sharpness — rendering every feature equally detailed with hard edges, which reads flat and un-focused. Ask yourself: 'Which feature is the focal point?' (Answer: the eyes and mouth.) Then make ONLY that zone detailed and sharp; make everything else progressively softer. This is compositional hierarchy, not technique, and it separates professional portraiture from amateur work.

18 Final Highlights, Burnishing, and Wax Bloom Correction (Luminosity and Finish)

Peak light zones (forehead, nose tip, cheekbones, lips); entire smooth face area for final burnish;

Layered strokes

Heavy (highlights), Heavy (burnishing), Maximum (white accents only), Medium (re-darkening if needed) pressure



pupil catch light Apply PC914 (Cream) to the forehead apex and cheekbone peaks at heavy pressure in small circular strokes. Apply PC938 (White) to the very brightest point (nose tip, forehead center) at maximum pressure, but keep this zone tiny (fingertip-eraser-sized). Reserve true white for the pupil catch light if not already bright enough. Then, using PC914 (Cream) or a colorless blender at heavy pressure, burnish the entire face area in circular strokes, working systematically across forehead, cheeks, nose, lips, chin, ears, and neck. Burnish until no white paper texture or pencil flecks are visible and the surface reads smooth and painted. Allow burnishing to lighten values slightly (this is normal). If values become too light, selectively re-darken eyes, core shadows, and hair with medium pressure Indigo Blue, Warm Grey, or Brown, then burnish again lightly to set. Finally, wipe the entire surface gently with a soft dry cloth to remove wax bloom; if haze remains, apply a very light spray of workable fixative. Heavy (highlights), Heavy (burnishing), Maximum (white accents only), Medium (re-darkening if needed) The final pass combines two tasks: (1) placing brightest highlight accents in lit zones that read light but not yet at peak white, and (2) burnishing the entire smooth face area to create a finished, painted surface. Begin by adding cream and white highlights to the forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, and cheekbone peaks using PC914 (Cream) at heavy pressure and PC938 (White) at maximum pressure only in the smallest, brightest areas (nose tip, forehead center). Then burnish the entire face, ears, and neck using PC914 (Cream) or a colorless blender at heavy pressure in circular strokes, melting all pencil layers into a smooth, unified surface. After burnishing, wax bloom will appear (a hazy white veil) — wipe gently with a soft cloth or apply light workable fixative to remove it. The reason: burnishing melts pencil pigments into a wax film, creating the 'painted' finish. Wax bloom is natural and must be corrected. Additionally, burnishing LIGHTENS values — to recover depth, you must punch the darkest darks back up (eyes, core shadows, hair) AFTER burnishing before the final fixative.



Burnishing is NOT optional — it is the technical signature of finished colored pencil work. Many artists either skip it or burnish too early (crushing paper tooth before color is built). The correct approach is to build color fully, then burnish ONLY at the end. Burnishing will lighten your values — this is normal and expected. To recover depth after burnishing, punch the darkest darks back up (pupils, core shadows, hair tips) at medium pressure, then burnish lightly again to set. This 'burnish, darken, burnish' cycle is non-negotiable for final depth and visual impact. The wax bloom correction is also non-negotiable — a portrait left with bloom reads as if unfinished or neglected.